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Website Speed & Core Web Vitals Checklist

Fast pages are easier to use and easier to rank. Use this checklist to find the slow parts of your site, fix the biggest causes and keep performance from drifting after launch.

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1. Measure the pages that matter

Start with the templates that carry traffic and revenue: home, product, category, service and checkout pages. A perfect score on a page nobody visits is not useful.

- [ ] Use field data from the Chrome UX Report or your analytics platform to see real mobile performance.
- [ ] Use a lab tool such as PageSpeed Insights or Lighthouse to find specific causes.
- [ ] Test the same page more than once; third-party scripts and caching can change results.
- [ ] Compare mobile and desktop separately, and record the date of each test.
- [ ] Write a baseline for LCP, INP and CLS before changing code.

2. Fix images and Largest Contentful Paint

Images are often the heaviest part of a page and the element that determines LCP. Fix them before rewriting application code.

- [ ] Compress photos and use AVIF or WebP with fallbacks where needed.
- [ ] Set width and height attributes so the browser can reserve space.
- [ ] Serve the right size for each screen instead of one huge original.
- [ ] Do not lazy-load the main hero or product image; load it early.
- [ ] Use a CDN or image service that resizes and converts images automatically.

3. Reduce JavaScript and third-party weight

Every tag has a cost. Analytics, chat widgets, consent tools, fonts and A/B testing scripts all compete for the same main thread.

- [ ] List every third-party script and remove the ones nobody uses.
- [ ] Load non-critical scripts after the page is interactive or only when needed.
- [ ] Split large bundles and remove unused libraries.

- [ ] Audit tag managers so one container does not load dozens of tags on every page.
- [ ] Test with slow mobile CPU throttling, not only on a fast laptop.

4. Fonts, CSS and layout stability

Text should appear quickly and stay in place. Font swaps, late CSS and ads can all cause visible movement.

- [ ] Preload the main font files and use font-display: swap.
- [ ] Subset fonts and remove weights or languages you do not use.
- [ ] Inline critical CSS and defer the rest where practical.
- [ ] Reserve space for ads, embeds, banners and cookie notices.
- [ ] Avoid icon fonts when a small SVG set will do.

5. Hosting, caching and TTFB

A fast front end cannot fix a slow server. Check the time to first byte and how often repeat visitors can reuse cached files.

- [ ] Measure TTFB from the regions where your customers actually are.
- [ ] Enable compression and a CDN for static assets.
- [ ] Cache HTML only when you have a safe way to purge it.
- [ ] Keep server software, plugins and database queries under review.
- [ ] Watch for slow API calls and redirect chains before the page can render.

6. Test on real devices and monitor after launch

Performance is not a one-time score. New images, scripts and features will change it unless someone owns the number.

- [ ] Test on a mid-range phone and a slow connection.
- [ ] Check the main templates in a private window with a clean cache.
- [ ] Set a performance budget for page weight and Core Web Vitals.
- [ ] Monitor field data and alert on regressions after releases.
- [ ] Review the slowest pages every month and fix the top cause first.

> **Start with the biggest template:** improving a product or service page usually beats polishing the homepage.